

Newsom kicks off revision of voting maps

Democrats will ask voters in November to block Trump from ‘rigging’ midterms.

By Seema Mehta and Laura J. Nelson

Gov. Gavin Newsom, Democratic lawmakers and their allies on Thursday launched a special election campaign urging California voters to approve new congressional districts to shrink the state’s Republican delegation, a move that could determine control of Congress next year and stymie President Trump’s agenda.

The special election effort is a response to Republican-led states, notably Texas, pushing at Trump’s behest to redraw their congressional maps to favor Republicans and reduce the number of Democrats in the narrowly divided U.S. House of Representatives.

Speaking to a fired-up partisan crowd at the Japanese American National Museum in downtown Los Angeles, Newsom described the effort by Republicans as a desperate effort by a failed president to hold on to power by keeping Congress under his control.

“He doesn’t play by a different set of rules — he doesn’t believe in the rules,” Newsom said. “And as a consequence, we need to disabuse ourselves of the way things have been done. It’s not good enough to just hold hands, have a candlelight

[See Maps, A7]



AL SEIB For The Times



CARLIN STIEHL Los Angeles Times

TENSION AMID TRADITION

Djanai Johnson, top, hugs daughter Shaylee Robinson as they arrive for the first day of school at 24th Street Elementary on Thursday as campuses across L.A. Unified begin the academic year. Above, a bus arrives with students at Maya Angelou Community High School in South Park amid heightened concerns among families over federal immigration raids. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Libraries fight book bans with free e-cards



JULIANA YAMADA Los Angeles Times

LONG BEACH and other SoCal libraries now offer digital access to books through Books Unbanned.

By Annie Goodykoontz

There were 10,000 instances of book bans at public schools in the 2023-24 school year, according to PEN America. In 2024, 5,813 titles were challenged in public libraries and schools nationwide, says the American Library Assn.

“So many books for young people are being taken off the shelf,” said Fritz Bodenheimer, spokesperson for the Brooklyn Public Library in New York. “If you’re a young person, you know, you’re 14 or 15 years old and you’re just discovering yourself and maybe you think that you might be

a member of the LGBTQ community and all those books are taken off the shelf. What message does that send to you? That you’re a bad person? That you’re dangerous?”

To combat book censorship, some Southern California public libraries, including Los Angeles, Long Beach and San Diego, are joining libraries nationwide to provide access to online library cards. Children as young as 13 can get a free e-card to access the libraries’ catalog of e-books and audiobooks, without parental permission and without any challenges they may face to get a book in their local library.

[See Books, A14]

Putin would like to reach a deal, Trump believes

But the Kremlin says its aims in Ukraine are ‘unchanged’ ahead of high-stakes summit.

By Michael Wilner

ANCHORAGE — Vladimir Putin is lavishing praise on President Trump ahead of their high-stakes summit in Alaska on Friday, thanking his host for “energetic and sincere efforts to stop the fighting” in Ukraine over three years since the Russian leader attempted to conquer the country.

Trump, at the White House, also expressed optimism ahead of the talks, telling reporters he believes Putin “would like to see a deal” after suffering more than a million Russian casualties on the battlefield.

Yet Russian Foreign Ministry officials said Wednesday that Putin’s war aims remain “unchanged.” And an

aggressive Russian advance along the front lines this week provided evidence to military analysts that Moscow has no plans to implement a ceasefire.

It was a day of diplomatic maneuvering ahead of an extraordinary visit from a Russian president to the U.S. homeland, and the first audience Putin has received with a Western leader since the war began.

“It’s going to be very interesting — we’re going to find out where everybody stands,” Trump told reporters in the Oval Office on Thursday. “If it’s a bad meeting, it’ll end very quickly. And if it’s a good meeting, we’re going to end up getting peace in the very near future.”

Putin’s positioning ahead of the summit, and Trump’s eagerness for a deal, continue to fuel worries across Europe and in Ukraine that the Alaska negotiations could result in a

[See Summit, A7]

What’s in a name? More revenue for 2028 L.A. Games

By Thuc Nhi Nguyen

More than 40 years after L.A. produced the most financially successful Olympic Games in history, the 2028 Summer Olympics will feature a new advertising revenue path for the Games.

In an Olympic first, venues used for the 2028 Olympics and Paralympics will be allowed to have corporate sponsor names after LA28 and the International Olympic Committee came to a tradition-bucking agreement announced Thursday.

Historically, the IOC has sought to limit corporate influence by keeping venues free from advertising. Major sponsors are still ubiquitous at the Games, where only Visa credit cards are ac-

cepted and Coca-Cola products monopolize the concession stands, but venues and fields of play have remained commercial-free. The traditional clean venue policy has forced L.A. organizers to refer to SoFi Stadium, which will host Olympic swimming, officially as “2028 Stadium” or “the Stadium in Inglewood.”

Not only will the new agreement help logistically by not requiring well-known venues to adopt generic temporary nicknames, but it will ease costs as existing signage can remain in place outside of the venue.

“Our job is to push and our job is to do what’s best for the Olympics in Los Angeles,” LA28 chairman Casey Wasserman told The

[See Rights, A12]

Airdrops of aid set off desperate scramble in Gaza

By Nabih Bulos and Bilal Shbeir

OVER THE GAZA STRIP — The Jordanian air force C-130 Hercules cargo plane banked in a slow arc over the Mediterranean, pointing its nose toward Gaza for its approach — the final stage of the intricate ballet that is dropping aid over the war-ravaged enclave.

Earlier, in a cavernous hangar at a Royal Jordanian Air Force base, soldiers from Jordan, Germany, Belgium, the Netherlands, United Arab Emirates and Singapore assembled to prepare the 79 tons of rice, sugar, pasta, tomato paste, dates and other basic foodstuffs set for the day’s drop.

Despite the sweltering heat, the soldiers stationed at King Abdullah II Air Base worked quickly, the hangar an ants’ nest of activity as they secured 1-ton piles of aid boxes to pallets, wrapped them in protective fabric, then tightened the rigging before using a forklift to hoist a parachute above each one.

No less active were the crews of the seven dark-gray C-130s arrayed on the tarmac nearby, their bellies open as loadmasters pre-

pared the planes for their cargo.

“We have to get a 100% success rate for the drops,” said Phille, a Belgian soldier whose tattoos, muscular build and clean-shaven head belied the gentle way he spoke as he tied a low-velocity parachute to a pallet. He gave his nickname, in line with the Belgian military’s policy.

“Everyone works in a chain, and knows exactly what they need to do,” he said.

Despite all that effort, everyone at the base that day knew that the multinational air bridge to Gaza was a wildly inefficient solution to a problem that by rights should never have existed.

Since March, Israel has kept the enclave under a near-total blockade, justifying the move as necessary to prevent aid from benefiting Hamas. The United Nations, dozens of aid organizations and Western officials have all rejected that claim and accuse Israel of deliberately starving the enclave’s 2.1 million people.

In May, Israel created, with U.S. assistance, the Gaza Humanitarian Foundation and charged it with delivering aid to Gaza. Aid groups and governments

[See Airdrop, A4]

COLUMN ONE

Migrant-tracking drones in Southwest

Far from ICE raids in L.A. and other cities, war on illegal immigration enlists high-tech devices that monitor the U.S.-Mexico border

By Steve Fisher

REPORTING FROM FT. HUACHUCA, ARIZ.

Inside a windowless and dark shipping container turned into a high-tech surveillance command center, two analysts peered at their own set of six screens that showed data coming in from an MQ-9 Predator B drone.

Both were looking for two adults and a child who had crossed the U.S.-Mexico border and had fled when a Border Patrol agent approached in a truck.

Inside the drone hangar on the other side of the Ft. Huachuca base sat another former shipping container, this one occupied by a drone pilot and a camera operator, who pivoted the drone’s camera to scan 9 square miles of shrubs and saguaros for the migrants. Like the command center, the onetime shipping container was lit mostly by the glow of the computer screens.

The hunt for the three migrants embodied how advanced technology has become a vital part of the Trump administration’s efforts to secure the border.

The Department of Homeland Security allocated 12,000 hours of MQ-9 drone flight time this year at the Ft. Huachuca base, and says the flights cost \$3,800 per hour, though an inspector general report in 2015 said the

[See Drones, A14]



BRIAN VAN DER BRUG Los Angeles Times

MOO-VERS AND SHAKERS

California has more cattle feedlots than any state, a new map shows. Above, a cow is readied for milking at a dairy in Bakersfield. **CLIMATE, A9**

Rams’ valuation hits its peak state

A commitment to SoFi Stadium investments, along with building a solid roster, increases team value. **SPORTS, B10**

Weather

Clearing. L.A. Basin: 81/64. **B6**

Markets **A12**
Opinion Voices **A13**

SpaceX launch plans rejected

Environmental and regulatory concerns cited over expansion bid. **BUSINESS, A10**

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